

Plural Adjectival Nouns

(When Adjectives Become Nouns)

Prof. Tommy Cherian
8547006780

Grammar

Error Spotting

Fill in the Blanks

Reading Comprehension

What is an Adjectival Noun?

Definition

An Adjectival Noun (also called a Nominalized Adjective) is an ADJECTIVE that functions as a NOUN in a sentence. When used to refer to a group of people, it takes a PLURAL VERB — even though it has no '-s' ending.



The word looks the same — but its ROLE and VERB AGREEMENT change!

The Golden Formula

THE + ADJECTIVE + PLURAL VERB

THE

Definite article
(always present)

ADJECTIVE

Describes a quality
(**poor, old, brave...**)

PLURAL VERB

are/were/need...
(~~is/was~~)

Example: "The homeless NEED our help."

Type 1: The "The + Adjective" Construction

Core Rule

Place the definite article "the" before an adjective to refer to a class or group of people. The noun formed is PLURAL in meaning.

Adjectival Noun	Meaning	Example Sentence
the poor	People who are poor	<i>The poor are struggling for survival.</i>
the wealthy	People who are wealthy	<i>The wealthy invest in real estate.</i>
the unemployed	People without jobs	<i>The unemployed need government support.</i>
the homeless	People without a home	<i>The homeless need shelter and food.</i>

✈ **Remember:** These words look singular but always take a PLURAL verb (are, were, need, want...)

Verb Agreement: Correct vs Incorrect

The most common error type with adjectival nouns

Because adjectival nouns are plural in sense, they always demand a PLURAL verb.

✗ *The poor is struggling.*

✓ *The poor **are** struggling.*

✗ *The blind was given free transport.*

✓ *The blind **were** given free transport.*

✗ *The unemployed has no income.*

✓ *The unemployed **have** no income.*

✗ *The elderly needs special care.*

✓ *The elderly **need** special care.*

Type 2: Categorical Groups

Adjectival nouns can classify people by their physical condition, social status, or age group.

Age	Physical	Social	Bravery / Quality
▶ The young ▶ The old ▶ The elderly ▶ The aged	▶ The blind ▶ The deaf ▶ The lame ▶ The disabled	▶ The poor ▶ The rich ▶ The homeless ▶ The unemployed	▶ The brave ▶ The wise ▶ The meek ▶ The guilty

Example Sentences:

- ***The young** are often more open to technological change.*
- ***Only the brave** deserve the fair.*
- *Braille is a system of touch reading for **the blind**.*

Type 3: Nationality Adjectival Nouns

Nationality adjectives ending in -ese, -ch, -sh, -ss

Nationality adjectives with these suffixes function as plural adjectival nouns when referring to a whole people.

FR The French [-ch]

The French are known for their culinary expertise.

CN The Chinese [-ese]

The Chinese have a rich history spanning millennia.

NL The Dutch [-ch]

The Dutch are masters of water management.

JP The Japanese [-ese]

The Japanese are famous for their work ethic.

GB The English [-sh]

The English have a long tradition of cricket.

PT The Portuguese [-ese]

The Portuguese were great maritime explorers.

⚠ *Singular form needs a suffix: 'A Frenchman' / 'A Dutchman' (NOT 'a French')*

Grammatical Constraint 1: No Possessive 's

Adjectival nouns do NOT take the possessive 's. This is frequently tested in the error-spotting section.

The Rule:

✗ *The poor's problems are ignored.*

✓ *The problems of the poor are ignored.*

✗ *The elderly's rights are paramount.*

✓ *The rights of the elderly are paramount.*

✗ *The blind's school is well-funded.*

✓ *The school of the blind is well-funded.*

Formula: Instead of [Adjectival Noun + 's], use **[Noun + of + the + Adjective]**

Grammatical Constraint 2: Abstract Singular

Don't confuse groups of people with abstract concepts!

Sometimes 'the + adjective' refers to an ABSTRACT CONCEPT, not a group of people. Here, the verb is SINGULAR.

PLURAL (Group of People) → Plural Verb

The poor are suffering.

The blind were given canes.

The brave were honoured.

The unemployed have rallied.

ABSTRACT (Concept) → Singular Verb

*The good **is** what we should strive for.*

*The unknown **is** often frightening.*

*The beautiful **is** in the eye of the beholder.*

*The sublime **escapes** all description.*

💡 *Tip: Ask yourself — 'Is it talking about a group of real people, or a concept/idea?' **If people → plural; if idea → singular.***

Grammatical Constraint 3: Using Quantifiers

many, few, most, some, several...

Because adjectival nouns are plural, quantifiers like many, few, most, some can be used. However, in standard English, you often need a supporting noun for clarity — unless the context is formal.

Quantifier	Formal (Adjectival Noun)	Standard (+ noun)
Many of	<i>Many of the poor lack healthcare.</i>	<i>Many poor people lack healthcare.</i>
Few	<i>Few of the elderly drive to work.</i>	<i>Few elderly people drive to work.</i>
Most	<i>Most of the homeless live outdoors.</i>	<i>Most homeless people live outdoors.</i>
Some	<i>Some of the blind use guide dogs.</i>	<i>Some blind people use guide dogs.</i>

Both forms are grammatically acceptable. Formal style (with adjectival noun) is preferred in government/official writing — important for SSC context!

Practice: Error Spotting (SSC CGL Style)

Exercise 1

Find and correct the error in each sentence

1. *The rich was asked to contribute more to the national relief fund.*
2. *The deceased's property was distributed among family members.*
3. *The unknown are what frightens all of us.*
4. *The French is famous for their cuisine around the world.*

Practice: Error Spotting (SSC CGL Style)

Exercise 1

Answers

1. The rich was asked to contribute more to the national relief fund.

'was' → **'were'** (The rich = plural group) | Rule: Adjectival noun → plural verb

2. The deceased's property was distributed among family members.

'deceased's' → **'property of the deceased'** | Rule: No possessive 's with adjectival nouns

3. The unknown are what frightens all of us.

'are' → **'is'** (the unknown = abstract concept) | Rule: Abstract singular → singular verb

4. The French is famous for their cuisine around the world.

'is' → **'are'** (The French = nationality group) | Rule: Nationality adjectival noun → plural verb

Practice: Fill in the Blanks

Exercise 2

Choose the correct word/form

Q1. The elderly _____ (is/are) given priority seating in metros.

Ans: are

→ 'The elderly' = group of old people → plural verb

Q2. _____ problems of the poor remain unsolved. (The poor's / The)

Ans: The

→ No possessive 's; use 'The problems of the poor'

Q3. The beautiful _____ (inspire/inspires) all great artists.

Ans: inspires

→ 'The beautiful' = abstract concept → singular verb

Q4. Many of the homeless _____ (lack/lacks) access to clean water.

Ans: lack

→ 'The homeless' = plural group; quantifier doesn't change plurality

Q5. The Japanese _____ (has/have) developed remarkable technology.

Ans: have

→ Nationality adjectival noun → plural verb

All Constraints at a Glance

● Verb Agreement

Always use a PLURAL verb with adjectival nouns referring to groups.

The poor ARE | The blind NEED | The French HAVE

? Abstract vs Plural

'The + adjective' for abstract ideas takes SINGULAR verb.

The unknown IS | The beautiful INSPIRES

? Quantifiers

Use 'many of the poor' (formal) or 'many poor people' (standard).

Both are correct; context determines choice.

● No Possessive 's

Never use 's with adjectival nouns.

WRONG: the poor's → RIGHT: the problems of the poor

? Nationality Nouns

Nationalities in -ese/-ch/-sh are plural.

The French ARE | The Chinese HAVE | The Dutch ARE

○ Singular Form

For ONE person from a nationality, add a suffix.

A Frenchman | A Dutchman | A Japanese man

Master Summary Table

Type	Examples	Verb	Key Rule
The + Adjective (People)	The poor, The brave, The elderly	Plural (are/were)	Always plural verb
Nationality (-ese/-ch/-sh)	The French, The Chinese	Plural (are/have)	Whole people → plural
Abstract Concept	The unknown, The beautiful	Singular (is/was)	Concept → singular verb
With Possessive	Problems of the poor	—	Never use 's directly
With Quantifier (Formal)	Many of the poor	Plural (lack/need)	Quantifier does not change plural